
Coming of Age on a Shoestring Budget: Financial Capability and Financial Behaviors of Lower-Income Millennials

Stacia West and Terri Friedline

Lower-income millennials make important financial decisions that may affect their future financial well-being. With limited resources, this population is at risk for acquiring too much debt or being unprepared for a financial emergency that can send them further into poverty and constrain their ability to leverage resources for future economic mobility. A financial capability approach, an intervention that combines financial education with financial inclusion through the use of a savings account, may correlate with millennials' healthy financial behaviors. This study used data from the 2012 National Financial Capability Study to examine the relationship between financial capability and the financial behaviors of lower-income millennials between the ages of 18 and 34 years ($N = 2,578$). Compared with those lower-income millennials who were financially excluded, those who were financially capable were also 171 percent more likely to afford an unexpected expense, 182 percent more likely to save for emergencies, and 34 percent less likely to carry too much debt, relating to their greater overall financial satisfaction. The findings of this study indicate that interventions that develop lower-income millennials' financial capability may be effective for promoting healthy financial behaviors.

KEY WORDS: *debt; emergency savings; financial capability; low income; young adults*

Millennials—the current young adult generation born between 1980 and 2009 and ranging in age from 18 through 34 years (Taylor, Doherty, Parker, & Krishnamurthy, 2014)—negotiate complex financial behaviors in a macro-economic environment that is markedly different from that of previous generations. Born into financially liberalized markets with variable interest rates and easily accessible lines of credit (Castranova & Hagstrom, 2004), this generation has struggled with high rates of housing debt (Emmons & Noeth, 2014), student loan debt (Elliott & Lewis, 2014), and an unstable labor market (Levenson, 2010). The financial behaviors of these young adults today may shape their financial well-being of tomorrow, potentially hindering their later ability to accumulate wealth (Friedline, Johnson, & Hughes, 2014). It is within this context that we seek to understand the relationship between lower-income millennials' *financial capability*—financial education and financial inclusion represented by having a savings account, combined—and their *financial behaviors* like saving for emergencies, using alternative financial services, and carrying debt. The article begins by reviewing

the state of millennials' financial behaviors and documenting the potential of financial capability for relating to their healthier financial behaviors. The data, method, and results are presented, followed by a discussion of the key findings and concluding implications for policy, practice, and social work education.

THE STATE OF MILLENNIALS' FINANCIAL BEHAVIORS

The financial stakes are high for lower-income millennials who report being financially independent earlier in life (Shanahan, Porfeli, Mortimer, & Erickson, 2005) and lacking families who can lend financial support (Diemer, 2015; Wightman, Patrick, Schoeni, & Schulenberg, 2013), compared with their peers of adequate means. Given their fragile financial situations (Bertrand, Mullainathan, & Shafir, 2004), lower-income millennials may have difficulty negotiating financial decision making and behaviors and, thus, may struggle to prepare for their financial futures (Howlett, Kees, & Kemp, 2008). An unforeseen drop in income or an unexpected expense are common experiences in lower-income households (Collins & Gjerston, 2013; Mills & Amick, 2010).

Yet, one-third of millennials have no emergency savings (de Bassa Scheresberg, 2013), and lower-income millennials who have any savings at all only accumulate an average of about \$200 (Friedline & Song, 2013). Without savings to cover these unexpected events, some borrow from friends or family, turn to credit cards (Kim & DeVaney, 2001; Yilmazer & DeVaney, 2005), or simply skip paying a bill (Collins & Gjertson, 2013). Others use alternative financial products (de Bassa Scheresberg, 2013; Mottola, 2014), reporting that these products are more convenient and less costly than products offered at mainstream financial institutions (Servon, 2013).

Millennials must also navigate paying for college during their transition into adulthood. Lower-income millennials carry higher debt burdens (Institute for College Access and Success, 2012) and are more likely than their wealthier peers to take out private student loans (College Board, 2007). Although many students struggle to pay back student loans, lower-income borrowers also struggle to complete their degrees or avoid loan default (College Board, 2007), suggesting that their transition into adulthood coincides with considerable debt that may inhibit their financial well-being. With limited preparedness for emergencies, increased use of alternative financial products, and burdensome debt accumulation, millennials face obstacles that may threaten their overall financial happiness (Gutter & Copur, 2011), future financial goals, and transition to financial independence.

THE POTENTIAL OF FINANCIAL CAPABILITY

Financial capability may help address millennials' risky financial behaviors and, in particular, provide lower-income millennials with opportunities to establish healthy behaviors. *Financial capability* is an individual's ability to carry out healthy financial behaviors in an institutional context with opportunities that facilitate these behaviors. Two components, financial knowledge and financial inclusion, are the "building blocks" of financial capability (Sherraden, 2013). Financial knowledge may be associated with healthier behaviors like avoiding alternative financial services use and saving for retirement and emergencies (Brown, Collins, Schmeiser, & Urban, 2014; Cole, Paulson, & Shastry, 2015), though the effect of financial knowledge on financial behaviors may dissipate over time (Fernandes, Lynch, & Netemeyer, 2014). The second building block, financial inclusion, refers to accessible and affordable

financial products and services to underserved households (Sherraden, 2013) and may benefit millennials who are less likely to have a checking or savings account or are more likely to use alternative financial products (Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation, 2012). Along these lines, this study explored how financial capability, a combination of financial education and experience, related to the financial behaviors of lower-income millennials.

METHOD

Data

This study relied on the 2012 National Financial Capability Study (NFCS), as it is one of the few nationally representative data sets that asks detailed questions about financial capability. Data were collected online from a sample of 25,509 adults in the United States between July and October 2012. A detailed description of the NFCS and the data is available on the FINRA Investor Education Foundation Web site (<http://www.usfinancialcapability.org/>).

Measures

Five self-reported outcomes served as proxies for millennials' financial behavior, including *financial fragility*, defined as certainty regarding the ability to acquire \$2,000 in an emergency (probably or certain = 1; probably not or certainly not = 0); *emergency savings*, defined as use of emergency savings to prepare for unexpected expenses (yes = 1; no = 0); *alternative financial services use*, defined as use of title loans, payday lenders, tax refund advances, pawn shops, or rent-to-own stores (yes = 1; no = 0); *debt burden*, defined as indication of carrying too much debt (yes = 1; no = 0); and *financial satisfaction*, defined as satisfaction with the current financial condition (possible responses ranging from 1 to 10, with higher scores indicating greater satisfaction).

Financial capability was a four-level variable. Negative responses to having a savings account, money market account, or CD in the last 12 months and to having ever received formal financial education in a school or workplace were coded as 0, neither savings account nor financial education (financially excluded). Those with only financial education and no savings account were coded as 1 (financially educated). Respondents with only savings account and no financial education were coded as 2 (financially included), and respondents with both a savings account and financial education were coded as 3 (financially capable). Demographic variables included

race, gender, number of dependents, marital status, employment status, education level, household income (two categories: annual income of <\$15,000 and annual income of >\$15,000), welfare receipt, geographic region, and homeownership.

Participants

The sample included 2,578 millennials ages 18 through 34 with annual incomes below \$25,000. Approximately half (55 percent) of millennials were white. A larger proportion of the sample was female (54 percent) and unmarried (82 percent). Most had less than a high school education (60 percent), 32 percent had completed some college, and 9 percent had completed a college degree or more. In terms of financial capability, 8 percent reported that they were financially capable, 41 percent were financially included, and 5 percent were financially educated. Nearly half (46 percent) were financially excluded.

Analysis Plan

Markov chain Monte Carlo method was used to estimate five imputed data sets with no missingness (Schafer & Graham, 2002). Results were pooled across the five imputed data sets to reduce bias in the estimations of parametric statistics (Saunders et al., 2006). Propensity score weighting was conducted with multitreatments/dosages (Guo & Fraser, 2010; Imbens, 2000), which allowed for testing degrees of exposure to different aspects of financial capability and their relationships to financial behaviors. Logistic and multiple regressions were used to predict millennials' financial behaviors. Sensitivity analyses were conducted for alternative financial capability definitions such as whether young adults had a credit card, checking account, and ever had a savings account. To conserve space, these results are not included, but are available from the authors upon request.

RESULTS

Financial Fragility

Men were 77 percent more likely to be able to come up with \$2,000 in the event of an emergency expense than women, and those with a college degree were 105 percent more likely to be able to handle such an expense than those with a high school education or less (see Table 1, Model 1). Those who were employed or full-time students were significantly more likely to be confident in their ability to come up with \$2,000 than those who were unemployed, as were homeowners

compared with renters. Being financially capable and financially included were also significantly associated with the likelihood of being able to cover an unanticipated expense, 171 percent and 93 percent, respectively, when compared with being financially excluded. Being financially educated was not significantly related to millennials' financial fragility.

Emergency Savings

Millennials who were full-time students and those who were employed were significantly more likely to have emergency savings than millennials who were unemployed (see Table 1, Model 2). Those who owned a home were 148 percent more likely than nonhomeowners to have emergency savings. Financial capability and financial inclusion were significantly associated with the likelihood of having emergency savings compared with those who lacked financial education or were financially excluded. Being financially capable was associated with a 182 percent increased likelihood of having emergency savings, and financial inclusion was associated with a 126 percent increased likelihood.

Alternative Financial Services

Although financial capability, inclusion, or education were not significantly related to alternative financial services use compared with financial exclusion, results revealed associations among demographic characteristics (see Table 2, Model 3). Having one child or more was associated with a 56 percent increased likelihood of reported use of alternative financial services. Millennials were more likely to have used alternative financial services when they received government assistance or lived in the Midwest or South. Millennials were 31 percent less likely to have used alternative financial services when they had some college education and 52 percent less likely when they had a college degree or higher education.

Debt Burden

Financial capability was associated with a 34 percent decreased likelihood of carrying too much debt (see Table 2, Model 4). Millennials who were parents of one or more child were 17 percent more likely to report a high debt burden compared with those without children. Those who had completed at least some college or had a college degree or more were significantly more likely to report carrying too much debt than those who did not attend college, 49 percent and 71 percent respectively. Recipients

Table 1: Logistic Regression Results: Financial Fragility and Emergency Savings of Lower-Income Millennials (N = 2,578)

Covariates	Financial Fragility (Model 1)			Emergency Savings (Model 2)		
	β	SE	OR	β	SE	OR
Demographic control variables						
White	.120	(.151)		-.278 [†]	(.157)	0.757
Male	.569***	(.136)	1.766	.142	(.137)	
Number of dependents (children)	.045	(.089)		-.161	(.118)	
Married	.079	(.221)		.132	(.267)	
Education level (reference: $\leq$ high school)						
Some college	.163	(.141)		.081	(.157)	
College degree or more	.716**	(.199)	2.046	.187	(.205)	
Employment status (reference: unemployed)						
Full-time student	.705***	(.190)	2.024	.678**	(.202)	1.970
Employed	.571***	(.161)	1.770	.465*	(.191)	1.592
Household income	.261 [†]	(.138)	1.298	.146	(.173)	
Receives government assistance	-.093	(.178)		-.206	(.197)	
Geographic region (reference: Northeast)						
Midwest	-.204	(.203)		-.255	(.254)	
South	-.110	(.218)		-.132	(.247)	
West	.149	(.211)		-.150	(.242)	
Owns home	.648***	(.168)	1.912	.909***	(.184)	2.482
Variable of interest						
Financial capability (reference: financially excluded)						
Financially capable	.995***	(.168)	2.705	1.037**	(.265)	2.821
Financially included	.656***	(.123)	1.927	.814***	(.154)	2.257
Financially educated	.197	(.226)		.225	(.257)	
Constant	-2.420	(.296)	$p < 0.001$	-2.180	(.299)	$p < 0.001$
McFadden's R^2		.072				.093

Note: Lower-income defined as <\$25,000 per year.

[†] $p < .10$. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

of government assistance were 81 percent more likely to report a high debt burden than those who did not receive government assistance.

Financial Satisfaction

Compared with respondents who were financially excluded, those who were financially capable reported 1.041 points higher financial satisfaction (see Table 3, Model 5). Some college education was associated with lower-income millennials' significantly lower reported financial satisfaction compared with a high school education or less. Millennials who were married were significantly more likely to have higher financial satisfaction scores than their unmarried peers, as were millennials who were full-time students and employed. Homeownership had the strongest relationship with financial satisfaction, with homeowners reporting 1.123 points higher on the financial satisfaction scale than nonhomeowners.

DISCUSSION

Associations between Financial Capability and Financial Behaviors

With the exception of use of alternative financial services, lower-income millennials' financial capability is associated with avoiding risky financial behaviors and practicing healthy ones. Being financially capable has a stronger association with these behaviors than being financially included or educated. Compared with their financially excluded peers, financially capable, lower-income millennials are 171 percent more likely to be able to come up with \$2,000 in 30 days and are 182 percent more likely to have savings to equal three months of expenses. Financially capable, lower-income millennials are also 34 percent less likely to report carrying too much debt and report higher rates of financial satisfaction than those who have only financial education, a savings account, or who are financially excluded. Given lower-income millennials' high rates

Table 2: Logistic Regression Results: Alternative Financial Services Use and Debt Burden of Lower-Income Millennials (N = 2,578)

Covariates	Alternative Financial Services			Debt Burden		
	(Model 3)			(Model 4)		
	β	SE	OR	β	SE	OR
Demographic control variables						
White	-.184	(.134)		-.190	(.125)	
Male	.253 [†]	(.137)	1.288	-.070	(.127)	
Number of dependents (children)	.443***	(.088)	1.557	.159*	(.064)	1.172
Married	.061	(.216)		.083	(.176)	
Education level (reference: $\leq$ high school)						
Some college	-.372*	(.151)	.689	.399**	(.142)	1.490
College degree or more	-.744***	(.192)	.475	.537**	(.184)	1.711
Employment status (reference: unemployed)						
Full-time student	-.417*	(.186)	.659	-.257	(.176)	
Employed	.001	(.148)		.038	(.139)	
Household income	.355*	(.137)	1.426	-.065	(.123)	
Receives government assistance	.633***	(.149)	1.883	.593***	(.146)	1.809
Geographic region (reference: Northeast)						
Midwest	.505*	(.235)	1.657	.188	(.200)	
South	.455*	(.219)	1.576	-.062	(.192)	
West	.272	(.225)		-.033	(.201)	
Owns home	.156	(.188)		-.146	(.170)	
Variable of interest						
Financial capability (reference: financially excluded)						
Financially capable	-.316	(.200)		-.423*	(.184)	0.655
Financially included	-.130	(.120)		-.124	(.112)	
Financially educated	.179	(.212)		.077	(.191)	
Constant	-.694	(.259)	$p = .007$	-.867	(.227)	$p < 0.001$
McFadden's R^2			.107			.037

Note: Lower-income defined as < \$25,000 per year.

[†] $p < .10$. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

of credit card debt (Jiang & Dunn, 2013), it may be the case that those who are financially capable are more aware of the financial consequences of carrying too much debt. The building blocks of financial capability—both financial education and financial inclusion through use of savings accounts—may be key to helping lower-income millennials make more sound financial behaviors as they negotiate a number of complexities at this stage of the life course and carrying out their preferred financial lives. Notably, financial education by itself appears to make no difference in the ways that lower-income millennials report preparing for financial emergencies.

Implications for Policy, Practice, and Social Work Education

Several federal proposals endorse financial capability as a strategy for improving financial behaviors. Child Savings Accounts, proposed under the America Saving for Personal Investment, Retirement, and Education

(ASPIRE) Act and the USAccounts: Investing in America's Future Act would provide a savings account supplemented with an initial deposit for each child born in the United States and provide an opportunity for children and parents to gain financial knowledge (Cramer, 2010). Individual Development Account, a program made available through the 1998 Assets for Independence Act that supports saving for lower-income participants through matching deposits and financial education (Schreiner & Sherraden, 2007), could be altered to allow withdrawals in the event of an emergency (Adams & West, 2015).

Attending to financial capability in direct social practice with clients is both an issue of social work education and balancing the onus for behavioral change on the part of the client and institutions. Lower-income millennials may engage with social workers as they seek services to address their financial difficulties, giving these professionals an opportunity to assist them in building their financial

Table 3: Multiple Regression Results: Financial Satisfaction of Lower-Income Millennials Ages 18 through 34 (N = 2,578)

Covariates	Financial Satisfaction	
	(Model 5)	
	β	(SE)
Demographic control variables		
White	-.145	(.170)
Male	.240	(.159)
Number of dependents (children)	-.125	(.103)
Married	.529*	(.261)
Education level (reference: $\leq$ high school)		
Some college	-.498**	(.164)
College degree or more	.401 [†]	(.211)
Employment status (reference: unemployed)		
Full-time student	.979***	(.200)
Employed	.540**	(.164)
Household income	.198	(.170)
Receives government assistance	.207	(.191)
Geographic region (reference: Northeast)		
Midwest	-.128	(.279)
South	-.148	(.264)
West	-.221	(.280)
Owns home	1.123***	(.196)
Variable of interest		
Financial capability (reference: financially excluded)		
Financially capable	1.041***	(.243)
Financially included	.405**	(.147)
Financially educated	.024	(.240)
Constant	3.350	.295
R^2		$p < 0.001$
		.106

Notes: Lower-income defined as < \$25,000 per year. Sample weighted using the average treatment-effect-for-the-treated (ATT).

[†] $p < .10$. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

capability (Birkenmaier & Curley, 2009). However, social workers report they are unprepared to build clients' financial capability given their own limited knowledge and confidence regarding personal finances (Despard & Chowa, 2010; Despard, Chowa, & Hart, 2012). This gap may be addressed through targeted education offered as part of social work curricula and through continuing education (Collins & Birkenmaier, 2013; Rochelle, McClendon, Brackett, Wright, & Sherraden, 2015).

For clients, financial education delivered in concert with opportunities to engage with financial institutions may be the most effective way to improve financial behaviors. For example, clients may be directed toward VITA tax preparation services that connect filers with the opportunity to designate a portion of their tax refund to a savings account and, in some cases, to have their savings matched. This study, as well as many others, has suggested that financial education delivered alone has little to no association

with financial behaviors, especially among lower-income populations (see, for example, Fernandes et al., 2014). An approach that couples hands-on experiences with formal financial education aligns with the theoretical framework of financial capability, as it emphasizes the importance of connecting individual and institutional opportunities to build financial capacity (Sherraden, 2013).

LIMITATIONS AND CONCLUSION

Findings should be considered in light of several limitations. First, the use of nonrandomized, cross-sectional observational data did not allow for causal testing. While dosages were created and observed bias accounted for using propensity score analyses (Guo & Fraser, 2010), unobserved bias could still have been introduced into the results. Despite these limitations, this article is one of the first to test lower-income millennials' financial capability

defined as the combination of a savings account and financial education.

Attention to financial capability and financial behaviors is especially relevant in an era in which lower-income millennials are making complex financial decisions. The behaviors that flow from these decisions and their results may have long-term implications for their abilities to achieve financial stability and to accumulate wealth. Lower-income millennials who overcome income insufficiency and save for emergencies, avoid using alternative financial services, and carry manageable debt may find themselves in a more stable financial position on which they can leverage to their benefit. Conversely, the lower-income millennial who is unable to put away savings for an emergency, relies on high-cost alternative financial services, and accrues sizable debt loads likely will be unable to save and have a financially stable future. These millennials may struggle to hold on to their financial stability, let alone achieve economic mobility. Although these decisions may appear to be purely individual behaviors over which lower-income millennials have ultimate control, lower-income millennials may behave accordingly based on the knowledge and opportunities available to them via institutional arrangements embedded into education, labor market participation, and opportunities for asset accumulation. **SW**

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Original manuscript received August 12, 2015
Final revision received November 3, 2015
Accepted November 30, 2015
Advance Access Publication August 29, 2016

NATIONAL ASSOCIATION OF SOCIAL WORKERS
POLICY STATEMENTS 2015–2017

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ISBN: 978-0-87101-459-7. 2015.
Item #4597. 392 pages. \$51.99.
1-800-227-3590 • www.naswpress.org


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